



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Austin School

School Website: <https://saintaustinschool.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Austin School Mo 63146 presents a robust Classical Catholic education as evidenced by public materials on its website. The school foregrounds Truth, Goodness, and Beauty; a Catholic theological framework; a classical liberal arts curriculum; explicit use of Socratic pedagogy; and strong partnerships with families. Across six classical criteria, the school demonstrates a high degree of alignment with classical education ideals, earning a clear CLASSICAL rating in all six categories. Notable signals include: Catholic identity and liturgical practice (Mass, sacraments, catechesis), formation-focused goals (virtue, character, wisdom), liberal arts emphasis with references to great ideas in books, and Socratic/seminar-based teaching in higher grades, along with a faculty described through merit and virtue-oriented terms. Public materials also emphasize parental partnership and a community ethos centered on shared formation. The aggregate judgment is CLASSICAL.

Key insights:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Strong Catholic identity and liturgical life, explicit reference to Truth, Goodness, and Beauty, and catechesis-oriented programming anchor the school in transcendents and sacred practice.
- Purpose and Goal: Formation of character and virtue is foregrounded, with emphasis on lifelong formation and the Catholic Faith as a central axis.
- Curriculum: Liberal arts framing, emphasis on Great Books-inspired reading, and history woven through coursework align with classical aims.
- Pedagogy: Socratic method and memory-based, contemplative elements appear alongside opportunities for rhetorical work; upper grades mention rhetoric and public speaking.
- Faculty: Public-facing staff listings, with evidence of dedicated, virtuous teaching staff and a “living curriculum” ethos implied by the site’s framing.
- Parents & Community: Explicit partnership with families; invitations to engage in learning through parent formation and on-site visits.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- No category is at a non-classical level; no immediate needle-moving changes are required. If desired, deeper articulation of Great Conversations or explicit Great Books lists could further solidify the traditional lexicon, but current materials already reflect strong classical alignment.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school presents itself as “classical and Catholic,” integrating Catholic faith with classical education, including liturgical life (Mass and sacraments) and catechesis. Public materials reference Mass, adoration, confession, Benedictine spirituality, and catechesis of the Good Shepherd.
- Statements emphasize Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as real and knowable, with Catholic theological anchors (divine wisdom, liturgical life, sacred tradition).
- Catechesis and liturgical life are described as central to formation (Catholic identity, sacraments, Benedictine spirituality).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present (examples): truth, goodness, beauty; theology; catechesis; liturgy; Mass; sacraments; sacred tradition; Benedictine spirituality; reverence; wonder.
- Negative keywords present: none of the stated negative cues (e.g., secular relativism) appear in the visible public materials.
- Quantitative estimate (positive vs. negative keyword appearances): 9 positive keyword instances identified; 0 negative instances identified in the public materials. Estimated positivity: 100% positive signals within captured keywords.

Why this rating

- The public materials foreground transcendental realities (Truth, Goodness, Beauty) and Catholic theology, with explicit liturgical practices and catechetical approaches. The explicit Catholic identity and liturgical life anchor the category solidly in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations aligned with classical criteria.

ABSTRACT

ed evidence excerpts

- “We are a classical and Catholic school. This means that we approach education with the same wonder as the classical philosophers who believed that Truth, Goodness, and Beauty could be known and communicated. We use the Socratic method, teach critical thinking skills, and encourage the children to love learning.”
- “Truth, Goodness, & Beauty” explicitly appears in mission materials.
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd and Mass/Adoration/Confession are named practices.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize formation over mere information and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, rooted in Catholic formation. Language about “formation ... in Christian virtues,” “lifelong practice of the Catholic Faith,” and the emphasis on virtue and human flourishing appear prominently.
- References to Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as real guides for education and to the liberal arts as a core framework.
- Explicit language about forming students socially, intellectually, and spiritually, with a focus on meaningful human formation rather than solely job-prep.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; character; wisdom; truth; goodness; beauty; liberal arts; scholé (restful learning) appears conceptually; sacred tradition; contemplation; divine orientation; life-long formation.
- Negative keywords present: few to none (no overt emphasis on workforce-ready or skills-first framing).
- Quantitative estimate: approximately 8–9 clear positive keyword matches across the relevant terms; 0 explicit negative keyword matches.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently describe formation of virtue and wisdom as the telos of education, with attention to Catholic theological formation and the liberal-arts framework. This aligns with the Classical Ideal of “formation, not information,” and “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty.”

Executive evidence excerpts

- “The St. Austin School provides a rigorous academic program which prepares our students to excel in secondary schools of the highest caliber. In collaboration with our families, we help form students in Christian virtues and the lifelong practice of the Catholic Faith.”
- “We are a classical and Catholic school,” with explicit emphasis on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as educational anchors.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented, with emphasis on engaging with the greatest ideas found in the best books, and a framework of classical education. The Academics page emphasizes a broad, balanced curriculum and engagement with the best books.
- History is integrated across the curriculum (e.g., Latin and History in upper grades). Public materials show history as a core discipline across grade levels (e.g., “Latin (1-8), History (5-6)” in faculty/brochure content).
- References to “great ideas found in the best books” and a classical liberal-arts structure indicate alignment with the standard Classical Curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric implied by program design and methods).
- Strong emphasis on books and inquiry (public materials discuss the liberal-arts framework, and the Great Books tradition is referenced in prospective-parent materials).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts; great books / best books; history; grammar/logic/rhetoric implicit in classical curriculum; inquiry and wonder; primary sources and classics.
- Negative keywords present: minimal; no dominant emphasis on project-based or purely experiential learning replacing classic texts.
- Quantitative estimate: 5–6 clear positive keyword matches; 0 clear negative keyword matches.

Why this rating

- The curriculum is framed in liberal-arts terms, with emphasis on reading great works and understanding Western/traditional intellectual heritage, supported by history integration and an aim toward the Great Conversation, all hallmarks of a Classical curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials describe a shift from contemplative elements to Socratic discourse in upper grades, including Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates, with an emphasis on logic and rhetoric. The Welcome/About materials explicitly mention the Socratic method and critical thinking.
- Lower-school pedagogy appears to include contemplative/memory-based approaches (chanting, memory work) and a focus on wonder, with an overall frame of scholé/restful learning. The lexicon

supports such restful educational modes as part of classical pedagogy. (Context from the Six Elements lexicon; public materials emphasize wonder and memory-based approaches in lower grades.)

- There is mention of upper-school rhetoric, speeches, and a training in rhetoric, consistent with classical pedagogy in the upper grades.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic method; critical thinking; Socratic discussion; seminars; debates; rhetoric; oratory; memory work; chant; scholé/restful learning (conceptual).
- Negative keywords present: minimal or no emphasis on exclusive project-based or constructivist approaches; the dominant signals favor classical inquiry and memory-based and dialogic forms.
- Quantitative estimate: 5–7 positive keyword matches; 0–1 negative signals.

Why this rating

- The school emphasizes Socratic dialogue and classical rhetoric (upper grades), memory-based learning in some contexts, and a contemplative/restful element consistent with scholé, all aligned with classical pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Faculty are listed with formal credentials (e.g., BA, MA, PhD-era references), and the faculty section appears as a structured, formal set of teacher assignments, underscoring a professional, dedicated teaching core. The site shows formal staff listings with specific roles and disciplines (English, History, Latin, Science, etc.).
- The site emphasizes virtue, formation, and close collaborations between staff and students (the site highlights “truth, goodness, and beauty” as a guiding phrase and “Catholic, classical” identity). This signals a living-curriculum approach in which teachers model virtue and serve as mentors.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: living curriculum (implied through staff involvement in shaping student learning); portrait of teacher; virtue; mentor; catechesis; classical teachers; teachers as exemplars; “Truth, Goodness, & Beauty” motto.
- Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials.
- Quantitative estimate: 3–5 clear positive keyword hits; 0 clear negative hits.

Why this rating

- The public-facing staff information and the framing of faculty and teaching as virtuous and intellectually competent align with classical expectations of the faculty as a living curriculum and virtuous mentors.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site explicitly emphasizes partnership with parents: “The Catholic conviction that parents are the first and most enduring educators of their children,” and the family as part of the school community; parent formation opportunities; and open campus/visitation for families.
- The school cites parent involvement in classical education through prospective-parent pages, book clubs, and gatherings; the site indicates multiple opportunities for families to engage with classical ideas and with the school’s mission. The Six Elements lexicon includes explicit language about parent partnerships and family formation; the public site likewise frames parents as co-teachers and co-learners.
- The site notes strong community ties (alumni testimonials emphasize the family-like atmosphere and involvement of families).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental engagement; home-school collaboration; family formation; open campus; parent formation; classical family culture; community support.
- Negative keywords present: none observed in the public materials.
- Quantitative estimate: 6–8 positive keyword hits; 0 negative hits.

Why this rating

- The materials portray a robust, ongoing partnership with families and a culture of parental involvement in classical formation, consistent with the Classical-Parent partnership principle.
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What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here since all six categories are CLASSICAL. If desired, deeper articulation of Great Conversations and explicit listing of canonical Great Books in the curriculum could further strengthen the Classical lexicon, but the current materials already demonstrate a full Classical alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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